Google Ad Grant Checklist

Up to $10,000 a month in Google Search ads for eligible nonprofits. Tick each box as you go.

1 Before you apply

Check eligibility and gather what the forms ask for.

- [ ] Registered as a 501(c)(3), with the IRS determination letter in hand
- [ ] Not a government entity, hospital or health care organization, or school (their charitable foundations can qualify)
- [ ] Legal name copied exactly from the IRS letter, punctuation included
- [ ] EIN ready (format 12-3456789)
- [ ] Address matches the IRS record
- [ ] Determination letter saved as a clear PDF
- [ ] A Google account on your organization's email domain, ideally a shared address, not a personal Gmail
- [ ] A second staff member named as backup admin
- [ ] Website on your own domain, loading over **https://**
- [ ] Website has real content about your mission and programs, and meets Google's Ad Grants website policy

2 Apply

Google for Nonprofits first, then Ad Grants activation.

- [ ] Sign in to Google for Nonprofits and click **Get started**
- [ ] Enter EIN, legal name and address exactly as the IRS has them
- [ ] Upload the determination letter if Goodstack asks for it
- [ ] Watch your inbox and spam folder for Goodstack email (verification usually takes 2 to 14 business days)
- [ ] Google for Nonprofits account approved. Date: _____
- [ ] Click **Get started** under Google Ad Grants and enter your website
- [ ] Watch the program video and check the box confirming you did
- [ ] Click **Submit activation request** (Google's review takes several business days)
- [ ] **Do not** create a Google Ads account yourself at any point. Google provides one on approval
- [ ] Ad Grants approval email received. Date: _____

3 First 30 days

Set the account up before it starts spending.

- [ ] Accept the Ad Grants account invitation and add your backup admin
- [ ] Link Google Ads to your GA4 property
- [ ] Pick 1 to 3 meaningful conversions: donation, newsletter sign-up, volunteer form, contact form
- [ ] Test that each conversion records. Page views and time on site are not conversions
- [ ] Campaigns organized by topic, each with at least 2 ad groups and 2 ads per ad group
- [ ] Keywords are multi-word phrases matched to a specific page. No single words except your own name
- [ ] A campaign for your organization's own name (it helps click-through rate)
- [ ] Location targeting matches the area you actually serve
- [ ] At least 2 sitelinks
- [ ] Bid strategy set to Maximize conversions or another conversion-based strategy

4 Monthly check

About 15 minutes. Put it on the calendar.

- [ ] Account click-through rate last month was 5% or higher. CTR:
- [ ] At least 1 conversion recorded, and the conversion rate looks believable
- [ ] Paused keywords with a quality score of 1 or 2
- [ ] Paused keywords with lots of impressions and few clicks
- [ ] No disapproved ads left unfixed
- [ ] New pages, events or programs on the website have ads pointing to them
- [ ] Google for Nonprofits email reaches the admin inbox, and the program survey is done when it arrives

Why the monthly check matters

Google can temporarily deactivate a grant account that drops below **5% click-through rate** for two months in a row, stops recording **conversions**, or misses the **program survey**. Fix the issue, then request reinstatement through Google's Ad Grants reactivation form. Want a hand? The first call with PhilanthroData is free: **philanthrodata.org/contact**

Notes